

Handle Success Like You Handle Failure: Pat in Her Own Words

Coach Path Summitt

The point that I'll make on teambuilding and things I've learned is how to handle success and failure. Sometimes as coaches, because maybe we feel more pressure or we think it means more to us than it means to kids, we don't handle failure. And I want to remind you to really check after a game on how you're going to handle it. I know, for me, a lot depends on the effort that was put right here on the floor. I don't want to teach effort, do you? I don't want to teach it. I don't want to have to try and coach it every day. There are things you can do to instill, through your competitive drills or whatever, better effort – a reward system, whatever. But you just hope that you've got kids that just absolutely love the game. But you're going to have some that just want to be on the team, without paying a big old price.

You're going to have to handle things when they don't go well. Somebody asked me how I handled our loss to Connecticut. And I told those kids it was a lot different from how we lost a year ago, because a year ago, we didn't have a team ego. We had a lot of selfish players. But this year, we had a group that really committed to playing together, and they just played a team that was better, and we didn't play well. The wheels fell off, and against a great team like that, it can get really ugly. You can sit there as a coach and it seemed like an 80-minute game, but it was just a 40-minute game. And I reminded them that the one thing that I would remember was what kind of kids they'd been every day and what kind of competitors and what kind of season we'd had.

I said, "I don't want you to think about that game unless you're thinking about whether or not you're going to work out in the off-season, and then you think about it. Then, you need to go the gym and take that with you and say, 'Here's how we'll get better.' Failure can bring out the absolute best in people or the worst. Success is the same way, and I addressed that earlier. But you have to look at this game and say, 'You never arrive. You never arrive. You're always striving to get better.'"